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ACADEMIC VAULT

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# Academic Integrity and Exam Rules: Pass Without Cheating

What misconduct looks like, why it is punished, and how to protect yourself

CAMPUS LIFE

## Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

**Written for students, by students.**

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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# Why this pack exists

Misconduct findings can end a programme faster than poor grades. This pack explains plagiarism, collusion, impersonation, exam-hall offences and the reasonable steps that protect you, including how to handle accidental similarity and how to study when you feel unprepared.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

## What you will be able to do

- Define plagiarism, collusion and fabrication with examples.
- Explain common exam-hall offences and their consequences.
- Protect yourself through correct citation and record keeping.
- Prepare adequately instead of relying on shortcuts.

## How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

## What misconduct includes

Integrity rules cover anything that gives an unfair academic advantage or misrepresents your work.

- Plagiarism: presenting someone else's words or ideas without attribution.
- Collusion: working with others on an individual assessment.
- Fabrication: inventing data, results or references.
- Contract cheating: submitting work written by another person or service.
- Impersonation: sitting an examination on behalf of another student.

- Exam offences: unauthorised materials, communicating during the paper, or refusing instructions from invigilators.

## Protecting yourself

Most accidental problems are avoided by good habits, not by knowing penalties.

- Cite as you write, not afterwards.
- Quote exactly with quotation marks and a page reference.
- Keep drafts and research notes to show the work is yours.
- Do not share assignment files with coursemates; share explanations instead.
- Follow the department's rules on collaborative work.
- If you are unsure whether help is allowed, ask before submitting.

> **AI tools**
> Check your department's policy first. If use is permitted, disclose it and verify every fact and citation yourself. If it is not permitted, do not use it - an acknowledgement does not convert a prohibited act into an allowed one.

## Consequences and second chances

Penalties range from mark deductions to expulsion, and they follow you.

- Procedures usually include a report, an investigation and a panel hearing.
- You are normally entitled to see the allegation and respond.
- Honesty during a hearing usually matters more than a defensive denial.
- A finding can affect scholarships, graduation and professional licensing.
- Failing a course is recoverable; a misconduct record can be permanent.
- Seek advice from the student affairs office or a staff adviser.

## What integrity means in practice

Academic integrity means producing work that is genuinely yours and attributing what is not. It covers examinations, assignments, laboratory reports, projects and publications, and it applies to collaboration as well as copying.

The line is not mysterious. Using someone's words without citation is plagiarism. Using their ideas without citation is also plagiarism. Submitting a purchased or commissioned assignment is fraud. Sitting an examination with prohibited material is misconduct. Helping another student cheat makes you a participant, not a bystander.

Collaboration is permitted where the brief says so and prohibited where it does not. If you are unsure, ask before you submit, not after you are questioned.

## Examination regulations

Know the rules before the day: permitted materials, identification requirements, arrival time, seating, and what constitutes prohibited items. Most examination misconduct cases involve a phone that was never used but was present, or notes left in a pocket from earlier study.

During the examination, follow invigilator instructions exactly. Do not communicate with other candidates, do not look at another script, and do not leave the hall without permission. If you need something, raise your hand and wait.

If you are accused of misconduct, the process matters: you will normally be informed in writing, given an opportunity to respond, and entitled to a hearing. Respond factually within the deadline. Do not attempt to contact the invigilator privately, and do not discuss the case on social media.

> **Empty your pockets**
> Before entering the hall, remove everything except permitted items. A phone found in a pocket is treated as possession, whatever you intended.

## Why it matters beyond punishment

Integrity protects the value of your qualification. If degrees can be bought, the degree of every honest graduate is worth less. That is the collective harm behind individual rules.

It also protects you professionally. A student who plagiarises an assignment is rehearsing a habit that ends careers - in journalism, law, medicine and research, attribution errors have ended employment.

The practical alternative to cheating is planning: start early, keep notes with sources, ask for help when stuck, and use the honest routes - extensions, study support, and speaking to the lecturer - that exist precisely because difficulty is normal.

WORKED EXAMPLES

# Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

## 1. Deciding whether collaboration is allowed

A friend suggests writing an assignment together.

1. Read the brief for any statement about collaboration.
2. If it is silent, ask the lecturer in writing.
3. If collaboration is permitted for discussion only, agree on ideas, then write separately.
4. Never share a document that will be submitted by both of you.
5. Cite any source either of you introduces.
6. Keep a record of the permission if it was given verbally.

> **What to carry forward**
> Ask before, cite always, and never submit shared text.

## 2. Preparing for an examination without prohibited material

You rely on your phone for notes.

1. Convert notes into a one-page summary you can revise from.
2. Leave the phone at home or in your bag outside the hall.
3. Check pockets and sleeves before entry.
4. Know permitted materials and bring exactly those.
5. Arrive early enough to settle without rushing.
6. If you accidentally bring a prohibited item, surrender it to the invigilator before the paper starts.

> **What to carry forward**
> Voluntary surrender before the exam is a different situation from discovery during it.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

# Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

## Q1. Explain what counts as plagiarism and how it is avoided.

*15 marks*

1. Copying words without quotation and citation.
2. Using ideas without citation.
3. Paraphrasing too closely, or reusing your own prior work without acknowledgement.
4. Prevention: notes with pages, running source list, drafting from notes.

## Q2. Describe the procedure following an allegation of examination misconduct.

*10 marks*

1. Written notification of the allegation.
2. Opportunity to respond within a deadline.
3. A hearing with the right to be heard.
4. Outcome and appeal route.

REFERENCE

# Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Plagiarism. Presenting another's words, ideas or structure as your own.

Citation. A reference identifying the source of information or ideas.

Collusion. Unauthorised collaboration presented as individual work.

Contract cheating. Commissioning work from another person and submitting it as your own.

Invigilator. The officer supervising an examination.

Prohibited material. Items not permitted in an examination hall.

Misconduct panel. The body that hears allegations of academic misconduct.

Self-plagiarism. Reusing your own previous work without acknowledgement.

Attribution. Identifying the source of a quotation, idea or data set.

Appeal. A formal request for a decision to be reviewed.

# Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Rules

Read them.

- Read the examination regulations.
- Read the plagiarism policy.
- Note the appeal route.

Week 2 - Practice

Citation.

- Cite every source in one assignment.
- Check paraphrases against the original.
- Ask about collaboration rules in writing.

Week 3 - Preparation

Honest routes.

- Start the next assignment early.
- Book study support if needed.
- Request an extension before the deadline if necessary.

Week 4 - Exam day

Procedure.

- Check permitted materials.
- Empty pockets before entry.
- Arrive early and follow instructions exactly.

## Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your institution's academic integrity policy.
- The examination regulations for your faculty.
- Your department's citation guide.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

## Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Define plagiarism.

Answer: Presenting another person's words, ideas or data as your own without proper acknowledgement.

2. What is collusion?

Answer: Unauthorised collaboration on an assessment intended to be completed individually.

3. How should you handle accidental similarity?

Answer: Paraphrase properly, cite the source and, where required, discuss it with your lecturer before submission.

4. Why is honesty during a misconduct hearing important?

Answer: It affects the panel's assessment of your conduct and can lead to a proportionate outcome, while dishonesty compounds the finding.

5. What is the safest approach to AI tools in assignments?

Answer: Follow the department's written policy; if permitted, disclose the use and verify all content yourself.

## Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read your university's academic integrity policy.
- [ ] Learn your department's rules on collaboration.
- [ ] Practise citing three sources correctly while drafting.
- [ ] Keep drafts and notes for every assignment.
- [ ] Check the policy on AI and other digital assistance.
- [ ] Know the procedure for responding to an allegation.
- [ ] Plan a revision schedule so shortcuts are unnecessary.

## Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

# Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

**Three ideas I can now explain without notes:**

**A question I still cannot answer:**

**For my lecturer or course rep:**

**Next revision action and date:**